

Prompt Engineering — Setup Checklist (v3)

Send this to students 48 hours before class.

If you skip this, the first 30 minutes of class will be people creating accounts instead of learning. Take 10 minutes now and you're set.

TL;DR — what you actually need

1. **One AI playground tab open and signed in** by class start. Pick whichever you already have.
2. **A Google account** (for the hands-on Colab notebook in the last 25 min of class).
3. **A laptop with internet** and the ability to copy-paste between two browser tabs.

That's the minimum. Everything below is the detail.

Step 1 — Pick your playground

You only need ONE of these to participate in the live exercises. We'll demo on all three from the projector, so you can follow along regardless of which one you have.

Option A — ChatGPT (OpenAI)

- **What you need:** any ChatGPT account (free tier works, paid is better).
- **Where to go:** chatgpt.com for chat. For the developer-style controls, also bookmark platform.openai.com/playground — this is the **OpenAI Playground** where you'll see the system message field, model picker, temperature slider, and JSON-mode toggle. Requires a paid account with a payment method.
- **If you're new:** sign in with Google or Microsoft. Free tier gives you GPT-5 with daily limits.

Option B — Claude (Anthropic)

- **What you need:** any Claude account.
- **Where to go:** claude.ai for chat. For the developer view, also try the **Anthropic Console Workbench** at console.anthropic.com → "Workbench" tab. The Workbench is the version with system prompt field, model picker, temperature slider — it's what developers use when iterating on prompts before putting them in code. Free tier exists but you'll need to add a payment method to use the Console.
- **If you're new:** sign up at claude.ai with Google or email. Free tier gives you Claude Sonnet 4.x with daily limits.

Option C — Gemini (Google) ← *easiest, no payment required*

- **What you need:** any Google account (you almost certainly already have one).
- **Where to go:** gemini.google.com for chat. For the developer view, **aistudio.google.com** is the no-friction one — full developer playground, free, no payment method needed. **This is the safest option if you don't want to deal with billing.**
- **If you're new:** sign in with your Google account. AI Studio gives you Gemini 2.5 Flash and Pro for free with generous limits.

Recommendation if you're undecided: Google AI Studio. Free, no billing setup, full developer controls. Use one of the others if you already have it.

Step 2 — One-time test (5 minutes, do this before class)

Open your chosen playground and run this exact prompt:

You are a friendly editor. Rewrite the sentence below in exactly two sentences, each under 15 words. Use everyday English.

Sentence: "The implementation of the new policy resulted in significant operational efficiencies across multiple departments."

You should get back two short, plain-English sentences. If you do, you're ready for class.

If you don't (the model gives you a paragraph, ignores the constraints, asks you a question instead), that's OK — that's literally the topic of class. But **make sure you can submit a prompt and get a response.**

Step 3 — Set up Google Colab (for the last 25 min of class)

The mini-lab uses a Python notebook in Google Colab. To prepare:

1. Sign into colab.research.google.com with your Google account.
2. Click "New notebook" — confirm a notebook opens and you can run a cell with `print("hello")`.
3. (Optional, but speeds things up) Get a free Gemini API key from aistudio.google.com → "Get API key" → "Create API key". Save it somewhere you can paste from. We'll use it in the last segment of class.

If Colab won't load for you (some corporate networks block it), bring a personal laptop or pair with a classmate.

Step 4 — Bookmark these for class

Open these in tabs before you walk in:

- Your chosen playground (one of A / B / C above).
 - Google AI Studio (for everyone, even if you picked A or B — we'll do cross-provider comparisons).
 - Google Colab (for the last 25 min).
 - The lesson cheat sheet ([Student_Cheat_Sheet_v3.pdf](#)) — keep it open or printed.
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What to do if your playground breaks during class

- **Free tier hit a rate limit?** Switch to one of the other two playgrounds (this is why we recommend signing into all three).
 - **API key not working in Colab?** Pair with a classmate; share their notebook screen.
 - **Your account got suspended for some reason?** Use Google AI Studio. It's the no-friction backup.
 - **Your laptop won't connect?** Sit next to someone whose does and pair-program. Pair-programming is fine.
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A quick mental note before class

We're not learning *one* AI tool. We're learning the **shape of prompts that work everywhere** — and looking at three providers to see how their UIs and vocabulary differ for the same underlying ideas. So:

- Don't worry if your chosen playground does things slightly differently from the demo.
- The point is the *concepts*, not the buttons.
- The cheat sheet has a "vocabulary translation" table for the three providers. Keep it open.

See you in class.

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